

In American politics since the 2020s, political figures have deployed AI-generated images, videos, and audio to attack opponents, create misleading narratives, or inflame emotions. The use of generative AI by American political figures has been subject to criticism from many sides of the political spectrum. President Donald Trump has used generative AI in several posts to Truth Social during his second term, many of which have made headlines due to their inflammatory nature.

Background

Generative artificial intelligence is a subfield of artificial intelligence that uses generative models to generate text, images, videos, audio, software code or other forms of data. In the mid-2020s with the release of 15.ai, ChatGPT, DALL-E and other generative artificial intelligence applications there was an AI boom.

There has been an increase of usage of generative-AI within the United States political field during this time, with both Republican and Democratic party members using it. The Trump administration during his second term, have embraced the use of AI-generated images, causing some misinformation experts to raise concerns about the continued usage would cause the erosion of public perception of the truth. In response to some criticisms White House deputy communications director Kaelan Dorr posted on X that the "memes will continue" with White House deputy press secretary Abigail Jackson also mocking concerns.

History of usage

2023

In April 2023, the Republican National Committee released an attack ad made entirely with AI-generated images depicting a dystopian future under Joe Biden's re-election.

2024

Generative AI has increased the efficiency with which political candidates were able to raise money by analyzing donor data and identifying possible donors and target audiences.

In March 2024 Democratic consultant working for Dean Phillips has admitted to using AI to generate a robocall which used Joe Biden's voice to discourage voter participation.

In August 2024, The Atlantic noted that AI slop was becoming associated with the political right in the United States, who were using it for shitposting and engagement farming on social media, with the technology offering "cheap, fast, on-demand fodder for content". AI slop is frequently used in political campaigns in an attempt at gaining attention through content farming.

2025

The initial version of the Make Our Children Healthy Again Assessment of children's health issues, released by a commission of cabinet members and officials of the Trump administration, and led by US Department of Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr., reportedly cited nonexistent and garbled references generated using artificial intelligence.

Democratic governor Gavin Newsom has used AI-generated images to criticize Trump.

In the midst of disruptions to food stamp distribution during the 2025 US government shutdown, anonymous social media users began using OpenAI's Sora to post slop videos of welfare queens complaining, stealing, and rioting in supermarkets; many comments to the videos appeared unaware that they were AI-generated, or acknowledged that they were AI-generated but nonetheless useful in pushing a narrative of widespread welfare fraud.

On September 6, 2025, Trump posted an image on Truth Social making a reference to "Chipocalypse Now". Trump's post consisted of an AI-generated image showing Trump frowning and wearing a US Cavalry hat and sunglasses, in front of Lake Michigan with the city

of Chicago behind him with a smoke and fire spread across the background with five US Army helicopters in the sky. The words "Chipocalypse Now" are rendered in a font resembling that in which the title of the 1979 film *Apocalypse Now* was styled.

2026

On February 5, 2026, Donald Trump shared a video of Barack and Michelle Obama depicted as apes in a Truth Social post. The two-second AI-generated clip of the Obamas portrayed as apes set to "The Lion Sleeps Tonight" appeared at the end of a one-minute-and-two-second-long video, the rest of which was about false claims of voter fraud during the 2020 presidential election. The post received at least 4,650 likes, 409 comments, and 1,470 reTruths before it was deleted the next morning. The short clip was part of a longer AI-generated video posted in October 2025. The post received widespread backlash and bipartisan condemnation of the video as racist.

In April 2026, Trump posted a picture of himself depicted as Jesus, drawing widespread criticism from Evangelicals and Catholics, resulting in Trump deleting the post hours later and claiming he believed he was depicted as a doctor.

Later in April, Wired revealed that a popular pro-MAGA online influencer, Emily Hart, was actually created through generative AI by a medical student in India looking to make extra money. He says he made a few thousand dollars a month. This followed an earlier disclosure that Jessica Foster, supposedly a young soldier who supported Trump and posted pictures of herself in uniform with him, was also entirely an AI creation.

Examples of use

Election campaigns

In 2023, while he was still running for re-election, the presidential campaign of Joe Biden

prepared a task force to respond to AI images and videos. The campaign for the 2024 Republican nominee, Donald Trump, has used deepfake videos of political opponents in campaign ads and fake images showing Trump with black supporters.

During the first five months of his second term in 2025, Trump posted several AI-generated images of himself on official government social media accounts, including him as the Pope, him as a Jedi, and him as a muscular man. In August 2024, Trump posted a series of AI-generated images on his social media platform, Truth Social, that portrayed fans of the singer Taylor Swift in "Swifties for Trump" T-shirts, as well as a photo of the singer herself appearing to endorse Trump's 2024 presidential campaign. The images originated from the conservative Twitter account @amuse, which posted numerous AI slop images leading up to the 2024 United States elections that were shared by other high-profile figures within the US Republican Party, such as Elon Musk, who has publicly endorsed the utilization of generative AI, furthering this association.

In 2024, Michigan GOP candidate Anthony Hudson posted an AI-generated video showing Martin Luther King Jr. endorsing his campaign, later claiming it was uploaded by a volunteer.

In his 2025 bid to be the Democratic nominee for governor of New Jersey, Rep. Josh Gottheimer drew attention and criticism when he released a TV ad that used AI to portray him as a shirtless boxer sparring with Donald Trump in a boxing ring.

In November 2025, the campaign of Mike Collins, a GOP candidate in the 2026 United States Senate election in Georgia released a fake video, generated by artificial intelligence, that depicted Democrat Jon Ossoff defending his vote on the 2025 United States federal government shutdown by declaring he could never say no to Chuck Schumer and that SNAP recipients did not attend his out-of-state fundraisers. The Collins campaign also shared an AI-generated video featuring Collins as a shirtless blue jeans model, referencing an American Eagle Outfitters advertisement featuring Sydney Sweeney.

During the 2026 Los Angeles mayoral election, candidate Spencer Pratt reposted an AI-generated video portraying Pratt as Batman and prominent California politicians such as Karen Bass, Gavin Newsom, and Kamala Harris, as unruly aristocrats. Former governor of Florida Jeb Bush described the ad as "maybe the best political ad of the year." In response, a spokesperson for Bass's campaign said, he was "doing his best Trump impression." Bass further responded that the AI ads are "taking on a violent trend."

In June 2026, during the United States Senate election in Texas, Citizens for Sanity aired an ad that used AI to generate a deepfake video of Democratic candidate James Talarico. In the video, Talarico is wearing a dress and sings a version of "My Favorite Things" that parodies his support for transgender people with lyrics such as "Boys in white dresses with blue satin sashes / Girls dosed with hormones til they grow mustaches." The ad did not disclose that AI was used in its creation, and it was connected to Ken Paxton and his allies having used Talarico's pro-LGBTQ stances to criticize him throughout the campaign.

Protests

In response to the nation-wide No Kings protests in October 2025, Donald Trump posted a video depicting himself flying a fighter jet and releasing feces on crowds of demonstrators, including Democratic influencer Harry Sisson.

Foreign interference

Officials from the ODNI and FBI have stated that Russia, Iran, and China used generative artificial intelligence tools to create fake and divisive text, photos, video, and audio content to foster anti-Americanism and engage in covert influence campaigns. The use of artificial intelligence was described as an accelerant rather than a revolutionary change to influence efforts. Regulation of AI with regard to elections was unlikely to see a resolution for most of the 2024 United States general election season.

Disasters and wars

In the aftermath of Hurricane Helene in the United States, members of the Republican Party circulated an AI-generated image of a young girl holding a puppy in a flood, and used it as evidence of the failure of President Joe Biden to respond to the disaster. Some, like Trump supporter Amy Kremer, shared the image on social media but acknowledged that it was not genuine.

In February 2025, Donald Trump shared an AI-generated video on Truth Social depicting a hypothetical Gaza after a Trump takeover. The video's creator claimed it was made as political satire.

Reception

Ramesh Srinivasan, a professor at UCLA raised concerns about the use of AI-generative images stating that many people are questioning where they can find trustable information, with AI systems potentially exacerbating and amplifying problems about the absence of trust, and understanding what could be reality. Michael A Spikes, a professor at Northwestern University raised similar concerns, stating that the government sharing these images was eroding trust that the public should hold that the government should disburse accurate, verified information.

Presidential historian and senior fellow at the Ronald Reagan Institute, Tevi Troy, raised claims that the use of AI is the latest adaptation by a sitting president, such as the use of the radio by Franklin Roosevelt and the TV by John F. Kennedy. John Nosta, an AI theorist shared similar opinions linking generative-AI usage to it being the evolution of Photoshop, but raised concerns that it could stray easily from augmenting communication to manipulating communication.

See also

Artificial intelligence and elections

Artificial intelligence in government

Misinformation about the 2024 Atlantic hurricane season § AI-generated images

Propaganda in the United States

Regulation of artificial intelligence in the United States

Slopaganda

Use of copyrighted works by the second Trump administration

References

External links

Media related to AI-generated content in politics of the United States at Wikimedia Commons